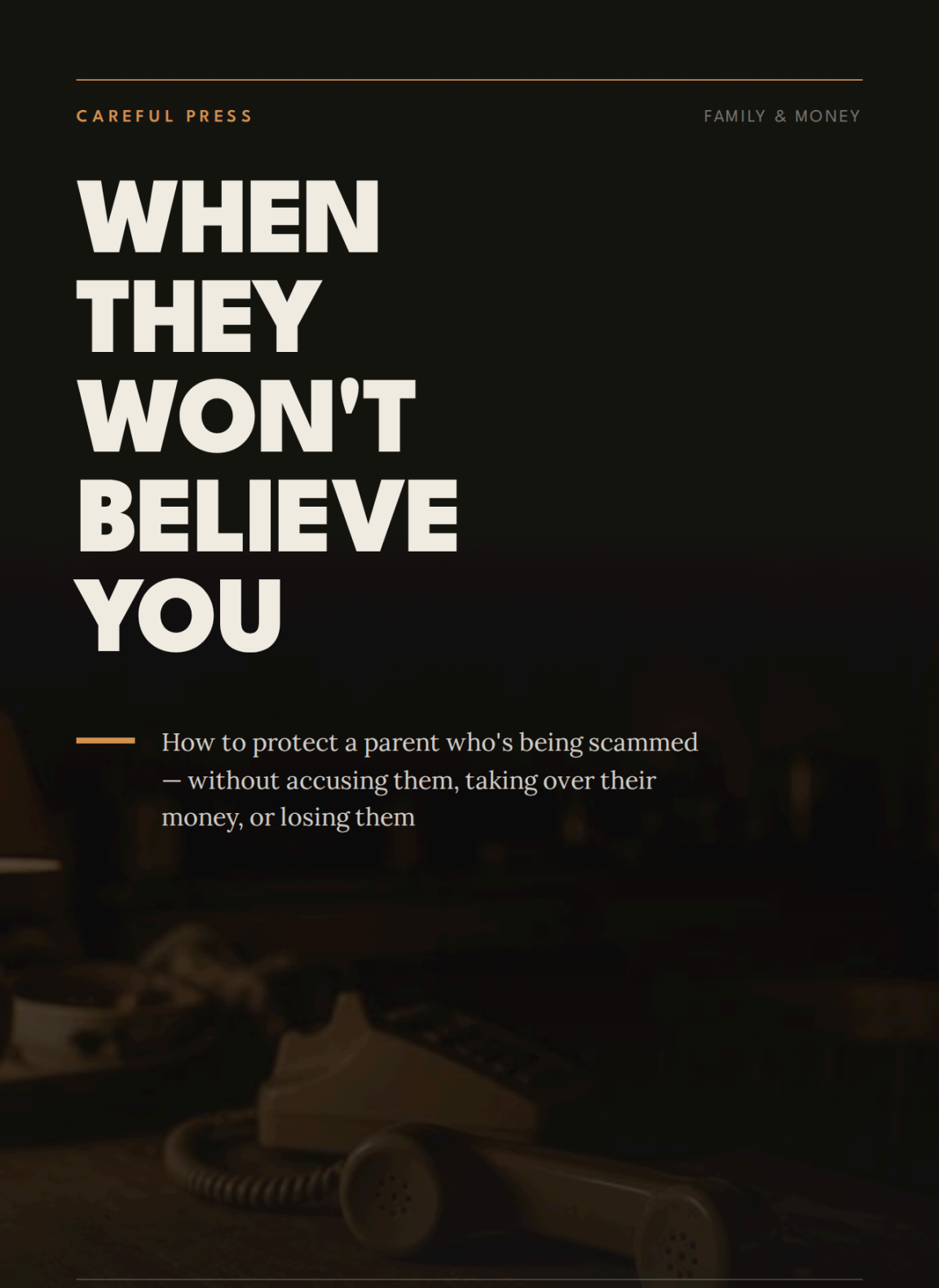
CAREFUL PRESS

FAMILY & MONEY

WHEN THEY WON'T BELIEVE YOU

How to protect a parent who's being scammed — without accusing them, taking over their money, or losing them



SEVEN STEPS, IN ORDER

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How to protect a parent who's being scammed — without accusing them, taking over their money, or losing them

Seven steps, in order. Built from 244 published sources — government and regulator guidance, law-enforcement reporting, and peer-reviewed research. Every one is listed at the back with a link, so you can check any claim in here instead of taking my word for it.

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READ THIS PAGE FIRST

If money is moving right now, do these three things before you read anything else.

1. Call her bank. Say the words "elder financial exploitation." That phrase routes you to a trained person instead of general customer service. You are giving them information, not asking permission. You do not need her consent to make this call, and you do not need to know all the amounts.

2. If someone is coming to her house to collect cash, gold, or a package — call the police. This is a real and documented method, not a far-fetched one. It is happening now, it is organised, and it is one of the few parts of this where police respond immediately.

3. If money left in the last thirty minutes by international transfer, call and cancel it. There is a cancellation window on international money transfers. It is short. If you are inside it, this is the single most valuable half hour in this entire book.

Free helplines, staffed by people who do this all day:

- **US — National Elder Fraud Hotline: 833-372-8311** (Mon–Fri, 10am–6pm ET). You can call about someone else. They assign you a case manager.
- **US — AARP Fraud Watch Helpline: 877-908-3360** (Mon–Fri, 8am–8pm ET). Open to family members, not just victims. You do not need to be a member.
- **UK — Action Fraud: 0300 123 2040.** For reporting.
- **UK — Victim Support: 08 08 16 89 111.** Free, 24 hours, and you can call whether or not anything has been reported to police.

Now go and do that. The rest of this will still be here.

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INTRODUCTION

YOU'VE ALREADY TRIED TELLING THEM

You have probably had the conversation four or five times by now.

You had the evidence. You had the reverse image search, the dates, the pattern that any reasonable person would recognise in ninety seconds. You picked your moment. You were careful, or you were not careful, and either way it ended the same: she defended him, you pushed, she got upset, and one of you left the room.

Maybe she said you were jealous. Maybe she said you had never wanted her to be happy. Maybe she said nothing at all and just stopped mentioning him, which is worse, because now you cannot see it happening.

And in between those conversations you are doing the thing everybody does. Checking. Wondering whether looking at her statements counts as protecting her or spying on her. Rehearsing what you will say next time and knowing it will go the same way. Lying awake working out how much is left.

This book is for that situation specifically. Not for spotting scams — you have already spotted it. For the part afterwards, when the person you are trying to protect will not accept that anything is wrong.

What this is

Seven chapters, in order, covering:

- What to do with her bank **before** you say anything — and why doing it the other way round can make things worse

- Why she cannot simply admit it, which is not stubbornness and is not stupidity, but arithmetic
- What to write down, what you may lawfully look at, and where to report it
- How to have the conversation so that it does not end the way the last four did
- Five different scams, five different psychologies, five different approaches
- What to do when it goes wrong, because it usually does the first time
- What the bank, protective services and the law can genuinely do — and what to do when the honest answer is that nobody can force this

It is built from 244 sources: government and regulator guidance, law enforcement reporting, and peer-reviewed research on fraud, persuasion, family conflict and how people change their minds. They are all listed at the back with links, so you can check any claim in here rather than taking my word for it.

What this is not

It is not a list of warning signs. That is the obvious thing to sell you and there is good evidence it does not work. When researchers gave a thousand people the standard scam-spotting advice, it produced no net improvement — people became more suspicious of everything, including genuine messages. And your situation is not a recognition problem anyway. She is not failing to spot a pattern. She is in a relationship, or in a panic, and neither of those is fixed by a checklist.

It is not legal advice. Guardianship, capacity and undue influence work differently in every US state and in every country, and they change. Where the law matters, this book tells you what kind of thing

exists and points you to someone qualified in her jurisdiction. It does not tell you what to file.

It will not get the money back. I want to be direct about this on page one rather than let you hope for forty pages. In 2025 the FBI's recovery operation froze around three percent of what was reported lost, and frozen is not the same as returned. If money has gone, plan on it being gone, and put your effort into the money that has not gone yet. Anyone who promises you differently is running the second scam — and there will be one, which chapter 3 covers.

It is not a guarantee. The approach in here is the best-supported one available, and the evidence behind it shows small effects, mixed quality, and durability often under six months. AARP, who have staffed a fraud helpline for years, say plainly that you might never convince your loved one. I would rather you knew that now.

Who this is not for

- **If she has a formal diagnosis of dementia**, the situation is different. Much of this still helps, but capacity questions dominate and you need specialist guidance this book cannot give. That line is not as sharp as it sounds, though. Many parents sit in a grey zone, with early changes in judgement and no diagnosis, and that is often exactly where a scam takes hold. If that sounds like her, this book is still for you, and chapter 7 explains why it is worth raising with her doctor.
- **If the person taking her money is a family member or a carer**, that is a different crime with different routes. Some of the escalation in chapter 7 applies; nothing else really does.
- **If you have already taken over her finances** under a court order or an active power of attorney, chapters 1 and 3 will be of limited use, because you have authority this book assumes you do not have.

- **If you want to be told you can fix this in one conversation**, this book will disappoint you. That is not cynicism. It is the reason the other advice has not worked.

One thing to hold onto before you start

You did not cause this.

You did not choose the person who targeted her. You did not create the loneliness or the fear he found and used. And you are not the reason she will not listen — that is doing exactly what it was designed to do.

The people who do best here are not the ones who win the argument. They are the ones who stay in the room.

01

MOVE THE MONEY BEFORE YOU SAY A WORD

If you have found out what is happening and your first instinct is to pick up the phone and tell them, put the phone down. Not for long. For about two days.

This is the one piece of sequencing in this book that people get wrong almost every time, and getting it wrong costs money that could have stayed in the account.

Here is why. From the moment you raise it, the situation changes — not because your parent changes, but because the person on the other end does. They have done this before. They know that families eventually notice, and they have an answer ready for it. In the research on how these crimes work, isolating the victim from their family is not an accident of the situation. It is a deliberate tactic, used from early on [1.36, 2.16]. Victims in one study described hiding what they were doing specifically because they were afraid a relative would take over and strip away their independence — so concealment felt like the safer option [1.34].

What that means in practice: the conversation you are about to have may well make the money harder to see, not easier. Not always. But often enough that it is worth spending two days first.

So the first move is quiet. You do it without announcing it, and none of it requires your parent's permission, because none of it touches their money.

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The five things to do first

1. Find out where the money actually is.

Not the amounts. The institutions. Which bank holds the current account, whether there is a brokerage or retirement account anywhere, whether there is a credit union, whether there is a card you did not know about. You are building a short list of phone numbers, not an audit.

If you already know this, it takes ten minutes. If you do not, resist the urge to go looking through their post or their laptop. There is a better route in chapter 3, and going through someone's private papers is both a legal risk and — if they find out — the fastest way to lose the conversation before you have had it.

2. Call the bank and ask to speak to someone about an elder financial exploitation concern.

Use that phrase. It is the one that routes you to a trained person rather than general customer service.

Understand what you are doing on this call: you are giving information, not asking for action. They will not discuss your parent's balances with you, and they should not. What they will do is take a note, and that note matters more than it sounds, because it turns your parent from an ordinary customer into a flagged one.

US banks have had federal cover to act on this since the Senior Safe Act came in, which protects trained employees who report suspected exploitation in good faith [1.8, 1.9]. And the federal consumer regulator

has been telling banks for years to watch for exactly this pattern [1.11]. The person you speak to may well have had training on it.

Tell them plainly what you have seen: the amounts if you know them, where the money is going, and how long it has been going on.

3. Ask about a trusted contact — and understand exactly what it is.

If your parent has a brokerage or retirement account, the firm is required to make a reasonable effort to get a trusted contact on file [1.1]. This is worth having. It is also routinely misunderstood, so be clear:

A trusted contact **cannot see the account, cannot move money, cannot block a transfer, and cannot make any decision.** The regulator's own words are that the role "does not have any authority over the customer's account, cannot make trading decisions for the account and does not act as a power of attorney" [1.4]. The consumer regulator says the same [1.12].

What it does is give the firm someone to call. That is all. It is a phone line, not a lock.

It is still worth doing, because the alternative is that the firm notices something wrong and has nobody to tell.

Its limits, plainly. A trusted contact is an early warning, not a key. The firm can call that person to check on your parent, confirm their contact details, or ask whether anyone holds legal authority for them, such as a power of attorney or a guardian [1.4]. The person named has no power to act on what they hear. To actually do something with the account, you need separate legal authority, usually a durable power of attorney [1.12].

There is no federal trusted-contact rule for ordinary bank accounts. Some states have passed their own laws letting customers name a

trusted person the bank may contact when it suspects exploitation [1.40]. Ask her bank whether it offers this.

4. Ask what alerts can be switched on.

This is the one with real, immediate value. Many institutions can set up notifications on specified account activity — large withdrawals, wire transfers, unusual patterns [1.11].

The catch: most of these have to be set up by the account holder, not by you. Which means this is one of the few things on this list that may require a conversation. You can often frame it without mentioning the scam at all — "Mum, would you set up text alerts on your account? I've been reading about fraud and it made me nervous." That is true, and it does not accuse anyone of anything.

Choose alerts that match what is actually happening. Most banks offer a menu: large withdrawals, wire transfers, new payees, changed contact details, new devices logging in, low balance. Pick the ones that fit the scam. If money is leaving by wire, a wire alert. If someone may have remote access to her computer, alerts on new devices and changed passwords or phone numbers. Switch on too many and she will start ignoring all of them.

Then teach the one rule about alerts, because scammers copy them. Fake "fraud alerts" asking someone to confirm a large transaction were the most-reported text scam to the FTC [1.41]. Whoever replies is put through to a fake fraud team that "helps" them move their money to safety. How to tell real from fake:

- A real alert tells you something happened. It does not ask you to click a link or give a password, PIN or one-time code.
- A one-time code is for you alone. Anyone who asks you to read it out, even someone saying they are the bank, is the scam.

- Your bank will never ask you to move money to a "safe account", or to pay with gift cards or crypto.
- Urgency and secrecy are the giveaway: "act in the next ten minutes", "don't tell anyone at the branch".
- Never use the link or the number in the message. Close it, then call the number on the back of the card or on a statement, or open the bank's own app [1.41].

Agree it with her when you switch the alerts on: "*When an alert comes, we never tap it. We call the number on the card.*"

5. Write down what you already know, before you talk to anyone.

Dates, amounts, the name being used, how contact happens. Do it now, while it is fresh and before any conversation muddies it. Chapter 3 covers what actually matters here and what is just noise.

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What a bank can genuinely do — and what it can't

Worth knowing before you ask for something that does not exist.

Brokerages have a federal hold power. For banks, it depends on the state. In the US, a rule covering investment firms lets them place a temporary hold on a disbursement when they suspect an older customer is being exploited — roughly fifteen business days, extendable [1.2, 1.3]. Two things about it. The firm **may** do this; it is not obliged to. And the federal rule applies to brokerages and investment firms, not to ordinary bank accounts [7.30]. For bank accounts, about half the states now have their own "hold" laws that let a bank delay a suspicious transaction, usually alongside a report to Adult Protective Services [1.40]. Ask her bank directly whether it can place a hold where she lives.

Nobody can freeze a competent adult's own account because their family asked. This is the hardest thing in this chapter to accept and the most important. Your parent is an adult. Unless a court has said otherwise, their money is theirs and they may spend it badly. A bank that froze an account on a relative's say-so would be in serious trouble.

What a bank can do is watch, flag, ask questions at the counter, and sometimes slow a transaction down while it checks. That is not nothing. But it is influence, not control.

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The two things people think they can do, and cannot

"I'll just get the bank to reverse it."

Mostly you will not, and the reason is technical but decisive.

The consumer protections people are thinking of cover transactions you **did not authorise** — a stolen card, a payment you never made. Report one of those quickly and your liability is capped at a small amount [3.23].

But in these cases, your parent *did* authorise it. They sent the money on purpose, believing a lie. That is not an unauthorised transaction, and the protection does not reach it.

There is one narrow exception worth knowing: international money transfers over a small threshold can be cancelled within **thirty minutes** of paying, at no charge [3.22]. Thirty minutes. If you happen to find out inside that window, that is the single most valuable half hour in this whole book.

Beyond that, the honest picture is in chapter 3, and it is not encouraging. Plan as though the money that has gone is gone, and put your effort into the money that has not gone yet.

"I have power of attorney, so I can stop this."

Not in the way most people mean it. And first, check which kind you have.

A *springing* power of attorney only takes effect when a stated event happens, usually a doctor certifying that she can no longer manage her own affairs. Until then it does nothing. An *immediately effective* one is valid from the day it is signed. In states that follow the uniform law on this, immediate is the default unless the document says otherwise [1.42]. If yours is immediate, you can already act on her accounts: speak to the bank, pay bills, set things up on her behalf.

What neither kind does is take her rights away. She keeps the right to manage her own money as long as she is able to make decisions, and she can revoke your authority at any time while she can [1.13, 7.34]. As her agent you must act in her interest and, as far as you know them, in line with her wishes [1.13]. Using it to move her money against her clearly stated wishes is the fastest way to have it revoked.

People get this wrong in both directions. An immediate power of attorney is a real tool, often more useful earlier than families realise. It is not a remote control for overruling a parent who still has capacity.

And you cannot freeze their credit for them. A credit freeze stops new accounts being opened, it is free, and it has to be placed with each of the three bureaus separately [1.21]. But it is placed by the person whose credit it is. The law explicitly allows a representative to place a *fraud alert* on someone's behalf [1.22]; the freeze route is not the same thing. What you can do is sit with them and help them do it — which, once they are willing, takes about twenty minutes.

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IF YOU ARE IN THE UK

The picture differs in two ways that matter.

You may get the money back. Since October 2024, banks have been required to reimburse most scam payments made through the standard transfer system, up to £85,000, with claims usually assessed within five business days [1.23, 3.29]. There is a small excess — but if the person is recognised as vulnerable, the bank cannot apply it [1.25]. This is a genuinely better position than US victims are in, and it is worth claiming properly rather than assuming nothing can be done.

Bank branches have a police route. Staff are trained to spot customers being coached through a withdrawal and can call the police to the branch while it is happening [1.27]. It runs in every UK force.

The limits still apply. It does not cover cryptocurrency, cash handed to a courier, or international transfers.

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Before you close this chapter

One action. Not five — one.

Call their bank and use the phrase "elder financial exploitation."

Twenty minutes. You do not need permission, you do not need to know all the amounts, and you do not need to have had the conversation yet. You are putting a note on a file. It is the single highest-value thing you can do today, and unlike everything in the chapters that follow, it cannot go wrong.

Then come back, and we will talk about why they cannot hear you.

END OF THE FREE SAMPLE

THAT WAS CHAPTER ONE OF SEVEN

The calls in this chapter protect the money. The rest of the guide is about the harder part: what to say to her, and what never to say, so she doesn't dig in further.

- ☐ **Why she can't just admit it**, and what that means for how you talk to her
- ☐ **Build the file, not the case**: what to write down and what you may lawfully look at
- ☐ **The first conversation is not about the scam**
- ☐ **Match the conversation to the scam**: romance, impersonation, "your account's been compromised", the grandchild call, crypto
- ☐ **When it goes wrong, and it will**
- ☐ **What banks, protective services and the law can do**
- ☐ The **Conversation Cards** and the **Containment Checklist**, built to print

> *Recommended by Harry Margolis, elder law attorney in Massachusetts, to the readers of his firm's blog. Steve Weisman of Scamicide called it "excellent practical information about how to deal with an elderly family member in danger of being scammed."*

Get the full guide (89 pages, instant download):

whop.com/careful-press/products/when-they-won-t-believe-you

The numbers in square brackets in this sample point to the 244 published sources listed at the back of the full guide. General information, not legal or financial advice.